

12,000

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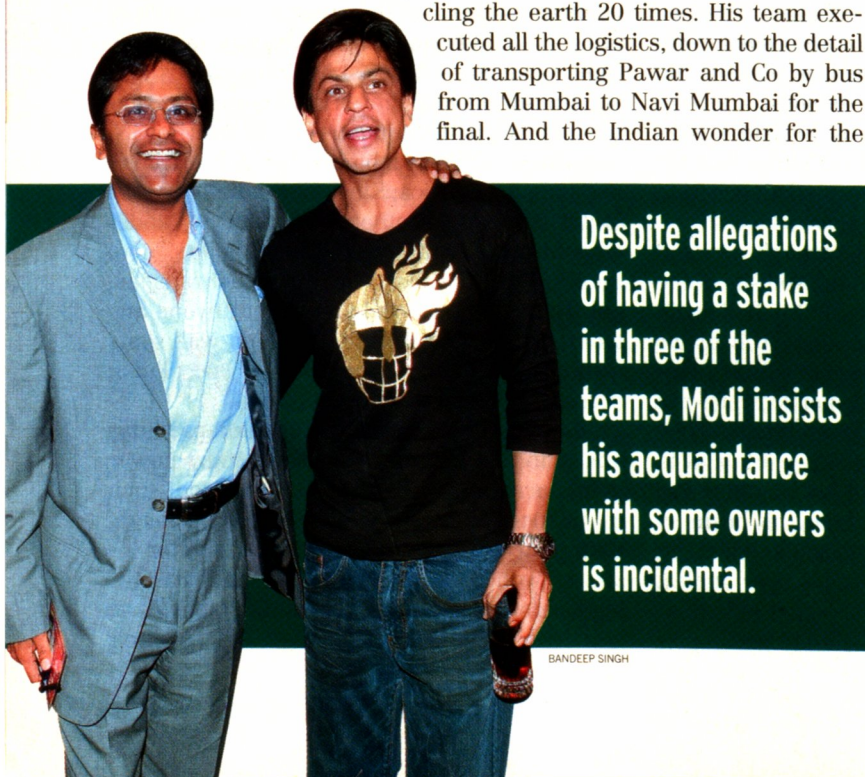
political clout to deal with law and order issues. Consider the logistics to get a sense of the scale of Modi's groundwork. The League involved carting 1,000 people—eight teams, nearly 700 BCCI officials and 100 representatives of sponsors—across the country every day. Over 44 days, that meant 12,000 hotel room nights and 20,000 air tickets. "There was no way we were going to allow a team to be late. So we tied up with ITC for accommodation and Kingfisher for flights," he says. Add to that two jumbo jets moving a 100-member crew across the country lugging tonnes of equipment. Modi himself logged 600 hours of flying in seven months—equivalent to circling the earth 20 times. His team executed all the logistics, down to the detail of transporting Pawar and Co by bus from Mumbai to Navi Mumbai for the final. And the Indian wonder for the

IN HIS SHADOW: Modi has found a mentor in Pawar (left), seen here with Shane Warne

world was that across 44 days there was no snafu, barring the power failure in Kolkata.

With success comes attention and there have been murmurs about Modi's impatience, bordering on the brazen, while dealing with BCCI officials, but IPL's goodwill has insulated him. He has found mentors in Pawar, Bindra and Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje, learning from them the virtues of being low-profile. The hyperactive Modi tends to answer e-mails, SMSes and questions at the same time, puffing on his Davidoff cigarettes. As Shane Warne and his team Rajasthan Royals walk away with the \$1.2-million (Rs 4.8 crore) prize money, one wonders what is in it for Modi. Quick on the take, Modi says, "Living this dream." It may just be the truth but the question is bound to haunt him as much as the success of IPL will.

Unperturbed, Modi is planning a second knockout season from 2010. Although he denies it, the big picture includes plans to sell a franchise in Dubai and move some matches to the Emirates (after all, the travel time from Mumbai to Dubai and Mumbai to Kolkata is the same) before entering the Americas. For now, it's a well-earned, four-week vacation in Capri, off the Gulf of Naples. It is entirely conceivable that Modi will have another light bulb moment as he lounges in his favourite tog of white linen bermudas and pink tee. Knowing that in India sequels have a patchy record, he will also be thinking of replicating his exploits in 2009. After all, he can't afford to be billed a one-summer success. ■



Despite allegations of having a stake in three of the teams, Modi insists his acquaintance with some owners is incidental.

BANDEEP SINGH